

You (Plural): Reading a Collectivist Book with Individualist Eyes

Nearly every 'you' in the epistles is plural, and nearly every reader in the modern West hears it as singular. That one grammatical fact rearranges more than we want it to.

THE GRAMMAR

The Pronoun We Cannot Hear

English collapsed a distinction the biblical languages keep. Greek and Hebrew both mark the difference between you singular and you plural, and in the New Testament letters the plural dominates overwhelmingly. When Paul writes 'you are God's temple' in 1 Corinthians 3, the you is plural and the temple is singular. One temple, built out of many of you, together. He is not telling each Corinthian that his body is a private sanctuary. He says that later, and differently. Here he is telling a fractured congregation that they are one building and that the man who splits it is wrecking God's house.

'Work out your salvation with fear and trembling' is plural. 'You are the light of the world' is plural. The promises we have printed on coffee mugs were almost all mailed to congregations.

This is not a translation scandal. It is a hearing problem. The text says what it says. We supply the singular because we cannot imagine being addressed any other way. That is the blind spot, and I share it. I have preached plural texts as private encouragement more times than I could count.

THE WORLD

Identity Was Received, Not Achieved

In the biblical world a person was a node in a web of kin. The first questions strangers asked were not about your career plans. Whose son are you. What town. What tribe. Identity came from outside, handed to you by family, village, and people, and your deepest obligations ran toward the group that named you. The modern West reverses this. We are trained from childhood to find ourselves, to define ourselves, to become ourselves, identity as a project the self performs on the self.

Neither arrangement is innocent. But the biblical writers assume the first one. That is why genealogies

matter, why barrenness is a public grief, why leaving father and mother for the sake of the kingdom is named as a real cost rather than a routine life stage. It is why the church's favorite word for itself was not organization or gathering but family. Brothers. Sisters. The household of God. Joseph Hellerman has shown that when the New Testament wants to describe the bond between believers, it reaches for the strongest bond its world knew, the bond between siblings, the one relationship you could not resign.

ACTS 16

When a Household Believed

In Philippi, Lydia believes and is baptized, and Luke adds without comment, and her household as well. The same night scene repeats with the jailer. 'Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household.' He is baptized at once, he and all his family. Cornelius before them, gathered with his relatives and close friends to hear Peter.

Western readers stumble here. Did each family member make a free individual decision. Luke does not answer, because the question is ours, not his. In a world where identity was corporate, the head of a household changing gods was a household event, the way a change of citizenship today carries the children with it. This does not erase personal faith. The jailer rejoices, Luke says, that he had believed in God, and the gospel will divide households too, father against son, when the group refuses Christ. But the assumed unit of decision was larger than the self.

We should not romanticize this, and we should not explain it away. We should notice that the New Testament never imagines a Christian whose faith is a private possession with no household, no body, no shared table.

THE BLIND SPOT

What We Miss

Read a collectivist book with individualist eyes and certain things go quietly missing. Church becomes a service provider for my growth, chosen and left the way I choose a gym. Sin becomes a private matter between me and God, though Paul treats one man's immorality in Corinth as leaven working through the whole loaf. Sanctification becomes a self-improvement program, though nearly every command in the epistles requires other people to obey. Bear with one another. Forgive one another. Confess to one another. You cannot do the Christian life to yourself.

Even our evangelism shows the print. We present a personal relationship with Jesus, which is true, and we fall silent about being joined to a people, which is equally true and came in the same package. The New Testament knows no salvation that does not place you in a body.

This is not a rebuke aimed out the window. The writer owns a study full of books about personal calling and an instinct, every hard week, to handle it alone. The individualist reflex is not something Western

Christians observe. It is something we are.

THE BALANCE

What the West Got Right, and What Remains

Honesty requires the other column. Individualism, at its best, protects something Scripture also protects. Ezekiel insists that the soul who sins shall die, the son not punished for the father, against a fatalism that buried persons inside bloodlines. Each of us, Paul writes, will give an account of himself to God. The prophets stood alone against their own kin when the group was wrong, and Jesus warns that the crowd, including the religious crowd, can be wrong together. A collectivism with no exit becomes a prison, and the gospel has broken such prisons open. Personal conscience, personal faith, personal accountability are not Western inventions. They are biblical notes our culture turned up loud.

The trouble is what we turned down. Scripture holds the person and the people in one grip, and we have let one hand go slack.

So read the letters again and hear the plural. You, together, are the temple. You, together, work out your salvation. The Bible is addressed to a people, and it was never meant to be read as private mail. We have been reading someone else's letters as if they were written only to me. They were written to us, which is harder.

KEY TEXTS

1 Corinthians 3:16-17

Acts 16:25-34

Philippians 2:12-13

SOURCES

Misreading Scripture with Western Eyes — E. Randolph Richards and Brandon J. O'Brien

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